



DevOps Leader

VERSION 2

Global Best Practice

For leaders and professionals ready to drive culture, transformation, and business value with DevOps!

Syllabus

Unlock
exclusive benefits
with PeopleCert Plus!

Join Now!



Official Training Materials





Published by PeopleCert International Limited
Published in Cyprus
Publication printed in Greece or reproduced electronically in Greece

Version 2.2.1 (June 2026)

Copyright © 2026 PeopleCert International Limited and its affiliates ("PeopleCert")

All rights reserved. No part of this document or the information in it may be copied, distributed, disclosed or used other than as authorized by PeopleCert. Information identified as being under a Creative Commons license may be used in accordance with that license. ITIL®, PRINCE2®, DEVOPS INSTITUTE®, LANGUAGECERT®, and the Swirl logo are registered trademarks of PeopleCert.

Disclaimer

This publication is designed to provide helpful information to the recipient. Although care has been taken by PeopleCert in preparation of this publication, no representation or warranty (either express or implied) is given by PeopleCert with respect to the completeness, accuracy, or suitability of the information or advice contained within it, and PeopleCert shall not be held responsible for any loss or damage whatsoever relating to such information or advice.

1. Introduction

The purpose of the DevOps Leader® certification and its associated course is to impart, test, and validate knowledge of DevOps basic vocabulary, principles, practices, and values. The vocabulary terms, concepts, and practices are documented in the Official Training Materials provided to the learners. DevOps Leader® is intended for anyone involved in cultural transformations and organizational change including IT team leaders, managers, directors and business stakeholders, practitioners and change agents, tool providers and systems integrators and DevOps consultants.

Although there are no formal prerequisites for the exam, PeopleCert highly recommends that candidates complete at least 16 contact hours (instruction and labs) as part of a formal, approved training course delivered by an Authorized Training Organization of PeopleCert to prepare candidates for the exam leading to the DevOps Leader® certification.

The DevOps Leader® examination is accredited, managed and administered under the strict protocols and standards of PeopleCert.

2. Exam overview

Material allowed	Official Training Material	This is an 'open book' exam. Official Training Materials can be used for study during the exam.
Exam duration	60 minutes	Candidates taking the exam in a language that is not their native or working language may be awarded 25% extra time, that is 75 minutes in total.
Number of marks	40 marks	There are 40 questions, each worth 1 mark. There is no negative marking.
Provisional pass mark	65%	Candidates need to answer 26 questions correctly to pass the exam
Level of thinking	Bloom's levels 1 and 2	'Bloom's level' describes the type of thinking needed to answer the question. For Bloom's level 1 questions, you need to recall information/knowledge about the DevOps concepts and vocabulary terms. For Bloom's 2 questions, you need to show understanding of these concepts in context.
Question types	Standard, Negative, Missing word(s), and List	The questions are all 'multiple choice'. 'Standard' questions have a stem and four answer options. 'Negative' questions are 'standard' questions in which the stem is negatively worded. For the 'missing word(s)' questions, there is a sentence with a word or more words missing and candidates have to select the missing word from four options. For the 'list' questions, there is a list of four statements, and candidates have to select two correct statements from the list.
Delivery	Web-based	The exam is offered only as a computer/web-based exam.
Badge	Online badge	DevOps Leader® Certified

It is recommended that candidates complete the DevOps Leader® course from a PeopleCert Accredited Training Organization (ATO).

3. Question Types

All questions are Objective Test Questions (OTQs), which present four options from which one option is selected. Distractors (wrong answers) are options that candidates with incomplete knowledge or skill would be likely to choose. These are generally plausible responses relating to the syllabus area being examined. Question styles used within this type are: 'Standard', 'Missing word', 'List' (2 correct items), and, exceptionally, 'Negative' standard OTQ.

Example 'Standard' OTQ:

What does the 'C' stand for in CALMS?

- A. Cooperation
- B. Collaboration
- C. Culture
- D. Continuous Integration

Example 'List' OTQ:

When putting the 1st Way into action, which **TWO** of the following should be **INCLUDED**?

- 1. Passing a known defect downstream
 - 2. Seeking an overview of the system
 - 3. Decreasing flow and adding constraints
 - 4. Allowing local optimization to cause global degradation
- A. 1 and 3
 - B. 2 and 3
 - C. 2 and 4
 - D. 3 and 4

NOTE: Two of the list items are correct. List style questions are never negative.

Example 'Missing word' OTQ

Identify the missing word(s) in the following sentence.

According to Gartner, [?] is the most common challenge for organizations adopting DevOps principles.

- A. People
- B. Information
- C. Process
- D. Technology

Example 'Negative' standard OTQ:

Which of the following is **NOT** a goal of DevOps?

- A. Improved productivity
- B. Fewer but higher-quality software releases
- C. Lower risk software deployments
- D. Improved quality of code

NOTE: Negative questions are only used, as an exception, where part of the learning outcome is to know that something is not done or should not occur.

Please see the sample paper for an example of the exam format and content.

4. Syllabus

The DevOps Leader® exam requires knowledge of the topic areas described below.

Note: The DevOps Leader® certification uses the Bloom Taxonomy of Educational Objectives in the construction of both the content and the examination.

- The DevOps Leader® exam contains Bloom 1 questions that test learners' **knowledge** of DevOps concepts and vocabulary terms (see list below)
- The exam also contains Bloom 2 questions that test learners' **comprehension** of these concepts in context

Category	Topic		Assessment Criteria	BL
1. DevOps and Transformational Leadership	1.1 DevOps Core Knowledge relevant for DevOps leaders	1.1.1	Identify key characteristics of DevOps definitions	1
		1.1.2	Name benefits of DevOps	1
		1.1.3	Explain DevOps as a combination of cultural philosophies, practices, and tools that enable high-velocity delivery of applications and services	2
		1.1.4	Identify DORA metrics that demonstrate how DevOps improves both throughput and stability.	1
		1.1.5	Identify how AI adoption improves throughput and stability	1
	1.2 Transformational leadership in DevOps	1.2.1	Identify factors that drive the success of DevOps	1
		1.2.2	Identify the current state of DevOps across various industries	1
		1.2.3	Recall the key characteristics of a transformational leader	1
		1.2.4	Identify tools useful for transformational leaders	1
		1.2.6	Describe how transformational leadership behaviours impact DevOps performance and culture	2
		1.2.7	Explain the Lean Strategic Change Canvas	2
	1.3 Purpose, soft skills and change tools	1.3.1	Explain Daneil Goleman's six stype of leadership	2
		1.3.2	Define the Golden Circle (why-how-what) as a model for purpose-driven leadership	1

Category	Topic		Assessment Criteria	BL
		1.3.3	Explain the Golden Circle (why-how-what) as a model for purpose-driven leadership	2
		1.3.4	Explain how soft skills (communication, empathy, collaboration) contribute to DevOps leadership success	2
		1.3.5	Describe the purpose of the Lean Strategic Change Canvas for planning and communicating change	2
		1.3.6	Describe the Lean Strategic Change Canvas to outline a high-level DevOps transformation scenario	2
2. Unlearning Behaviours	2.1 Unlearning and mindset	2.1.1	Define unlearning and mindset in the context of DevOps change	1
	2.2 Psychological safety, mental models, and cognitive bias	2.2.1	Define psychological safety	1
		2.2.2	Define mental models	1
		2.2.3	Define cognitive bias in business	1
		2.2.4	Explain how neuroscience relates to learning	2
	2.3 DevOps and existing systems	2.3.1	Describe how Agile, ITSM relate to the cadence of DevOps	2
		2.3.2	Explain how DevOps supports governance, risk and compliance (GRC)	1
		2.3.3	Explain characteristics of second generation Lean Product Development and Little's Law	2
		2.3.4	Recall principles for Enterprise Architecture to suit DevOps	2
		2.3.5	Explain how Flow engineering principles support DevOps	2
		2.3.6	Know how different skill shapes support DevOps	1
		2.3.7	Use a Bateson stakeholder map to identify key supporters and blockers for a DevOps change	2
		2.3.5	Explain the "Training from the back of the room" four Cs	2

Category	Topic		Assessment Criteria	BL
3. Becoming a DevOps Organization	3.1 Where to start and how DevOps differs	3.1.1	Identify attributes that do and don't favor starting DevOps transformations.	1
		3.1.2	Explain attributes that distinguish Traditional IT differs from DevOps.	2
		3.1.3	Explain how DevOps favors small batch sizes compared to traditional IT.	2
		3.1.4	Explain how DevOps favors autonomous teams compared to traditional IT.	2
		3.1.5	Explain how DevOps favors decoupled schedules compared to traditional IT.	2
		3.1.6	Explain how DevOps favors small, frequent releases, compared to traditional IT.	2
		3.1.7	Explain how DevOps favors decision making using self-generated data for decisions compared to traditional IT.	2
		3.1.8	Explain how DevOps favors decision learning from failure, compared to traditional IT.	2
		3.1.9	Explain how DevOps favors fast flow, compared to traditional IT.	2
		3.1.10	Explain how DevOps favors focus on outcomes, compared to traditional IT.	2
	3.2 MVP and customer focus	3.2.1	Identify steps to create a Minimum Viable Product (MVP)	1
		3.2.2	Identify practices to put the customer front and center	1
	3.3 DevOps Kaizen and safety	3.3.1	Explain how DevOps Kaizen improves DevOps transformation.	2
		3.3.2	Explain how to build safety in Behaviours and Systems.	2
	3.4 Participation and engagement	3.4.1	Define World cafe and Conversation Cafe approaches to encourage participation.	1
		3.4.2	Explain the role of "helping people participate" (eg wicked questions, Definition of Awesome	2

Category	Topic		Assessment Criteria	BL
			activity) in a DevOps transformation	
		3.4.3	Given a simple scenario, propose one “wicked question” that could unlock better engagement	2
4. Measuring to Learn	4.1 Value Stream Mapping (current state)	4.1.1	Identify Value-Stream Mapping process steps.	1
		4.1.2	Identify activity steps is Step 1 of Value Stream Mapping.	1
		4.1.3	Identify identification of cycle time for each activity is Step 2 of Value Stream Mapping.	2
		4.1.4	Identify identification of wait time for each activity is Step 3 of Value Stream Mapping.	2
		4.1.5	Identify how to calculate total cycle, wait and lead times is Step 4 of Value Stream Mapping.	2
		4.1.5	Identify how to identify high-value activities and key constraints is Step 5 of Value Stream Mapping.	2
		4.1.6	Identify how to add people and rework constraints is Step 6 of Value Stream Mapping.	2
5. Measure to Improve	5.1 Future-State Value Stream Mapping	5.1.1	Identify how the Three Ways help design the future state Value Stream Map.	1
		5.1.2	Define where to start future-State Value Stream Mapping	1
		5.1.3	Explain the purpose of a future-state Value Stream Map in optimizing flow	2
		5.1.4	Describe how constraints and non-value-added activities are removed in future-state design	2
		5.1.5	Identify practices for facilitators of future state value stream mapping	2
6. Target Operating Models and	6.1 Conway’s Law and Communication Paths	6.1.1	Define Conway’s Law	1
		6.1.2	Describe how communication structures	2

Category	Topic		Assessment Criteria	BL
Organizational Design			influence architectural outcomes	
	6.2 DevOps Target Operating Model (TOMs)	6.2.1	Define DevOps Target Operating Models (TOMs) design principles and practical outcomes	1
		6.2.2	Explain key DevOps TOM principles including autonomy and reduced dependencies	2
		6.2.3	Describe outcomes associated with effective TOM design such as reduced wait times	2
		6.2.4	Identify indicators of siloed behaviour inconsistent with TOM principles	2
	6.3 Agile and Ops Integration	6.3.1	Identify attributes of centralized Ops teams to support DevOps.	1
		6.3.2	Explain how Ops integrates with Agile teams through shared ceremonies	2
	6.4 Agile Scaling models	6.4.1	Identify different Agile scaling methods for large enterprises.	2
		6.4.2	Explain the difference between functional and market-oriented teams,	2
		6.4.3	Explain shared principles between DevOps and SAFe	2
	6.5 Spotify team and culture	6.5.1	Identify Spotify Squad structure	1
		6.5.2	Identify Spotify Squad roles	1
		6.5.3	Identify Spotify Tribe structure	1
		6.5.4	Identify Spotify Tribe roles	1
		6.5.5	Identify Spotify Chapter structure	1
		6.5.6	Identify Spotify Chapter roles	1
		6.5.7	Define Spotify Guilds	1
	6.6 Organization Culture Colors	6.6.1	Identify the five color levels from Frederick Laloux's book: "Reinventing Organizations"	1
		6.6.2	Explain the characteristics of the Teal organization	2
7. Articulating and Socializing Vision	7.1 Organization change	7.1.1	Identify keys to launching transformation change in a	1

Category	Topic		Assessment Criteria	BL
			large firm according to Forbes.	
		7.1.2	Explain characteristics of evolution of incremental organization change	2
		7.1.3	Identify characteristics of dysfunction team transformation	2
		7.1.4	What questions can different teams ask to propagate DevOps thinking.	2
	7.2 Performance Management & Beyond Budgeting	7.2.1	Define performance management and four stages of performance management for measuring DevOps progress.	1
		7.2.2	Explain Beyond Budgeting principles supporting adaptive performance management	2
	7.3 Empowering People	7.3.1	Define empowerment in a DevOps context	1
		7.3.2	Identify practice that empower people.	2
	7.4 Wilber's Quadrants	7.4.1	Explain Wilber's Quadrants and their relevance in organizational change	2
		7.4.2	Describe how quadrants represent individual and collective perspectives	2
		7.4.3	Identify which quadrant is most relevant in a given example	2
		7.4.4	Explain how balanced quadrant awareness supports change success	2
	7.5 Karpman Drama Triangle & TED	7.5.1	Explain the Karpman Drama Triangle and common drama roles	2
		7.5.2	Describe how the Empowerment Dynamic shifts roles to constructive alternatives	2
		7.5.3	Identify drama-role behaviours in leadership scenarios	2
		7.5.4	Explain how leaders support movement toward empowerment roles	2

Category	Topic		Assessment Criteria	BL
	7.6 Storytelling for Leadership	7.6.1	Define storytelling in a DevOps context	1
		7.6.2	Explain why storytelling is an effective leadership tool	2
		7.6.3	Describe the structure of effective narratives including conflict and resolution	2
		7.6.4	Identify storytelling elements that increase audience engagement	2
		7.6.5	Explain how stories support cultural alignment and motivation	2
	7.7 Broadcasting Outside the Organization	7.7.1	Explain why leaders broadcast successes and failures publicly	2
		7.7.2	Describe how external communication promotes learning and credibility	2
		7.7.3	Identify opportunities to share organizational stories externally	2
		7.7.4	Explain characteristics of effective public communication	2
8. Maintaining Energy and Momentum	8.1 Change Approaches (Revolution, Transformation, Evolution)	8.1.1	Explain Kotter's dual operating system and its role in transformation	1
		8.1.2	Know the types of change approaches: revolution, and evolution approaches	1
	8.2 The DevOps Business Case	8.2.1	Define the DevOps Return-on-Investment business case	1
		8.2.2	Explain the key components of a DevOps Return on Investment business case	2
		8.2.3	Explain how Lean Canvas supports framing investment discussions	2
	8.3 Culture & Climate	8.3.1	Define culture, climate, organizational culture, high-trust culture	1
		8.3.2	Explain differences between culture and climate using organizational examples	2
		8.3.3	Identify the components of the SCARF model	1

Category	Topic		Assessment Criteria	BL
	8.4 Technology Transformation Acceleration	8.4.1	Explain how technology transformations have accelerated over the years.	2
		8.4.2	Identify the four industrial revolutions	1
	8.5 Trust Require for Transformation	8.5.1	Identify characteristics of high-trust cultures	1
		8.5.2	Explain trust alliance principles	2
		8.5.3	Explain how reflection support organization learning.	2
	8.6 Kolb's Learning Styles & Experiential Learning	8.6.1	Explain Kolb's learning styles and experiential learning model	2
		8.6.2	Describe the value of Dojos and simulations in skill development	2
		8.6.3	Identify how embedding experimentation promotes learning.	2
		8.6.4	Explain how employee engagement tools can support leadership decision making.	2
	8.7 Shared Goals & Alignment	8.7.1	Define goals, shared goals, and alignment in a DevOps context	1
		8.7.2	Explain the importance of shared goals across teams	2
		8.7.3	Describe how shared goals support alignment and reduce friction	2
		8.7.4	Explain how fostering courage and curiosity support learning.	2
	8.8 Cadence & Rhythm in DevOps	8.8.1	Define cadence and rhythm in DevOps	1
		8.8.2	Explain the concept of cadence in DevOps teams	2
	8.9 Peter Senge's laws of Systems Thinking	8.9.1	Explain Peter Senge's laws of Systems Thinking	2
	8.10 Scaling learning across the organization	8.10.1	Explain how to transform local discoveries to global improvements	2
	8.11 Coaching	8.11.1	Practices for DevOps Leaders to be effective coaches	2

The candidate is expected to understand, comprehend, and apply the following DevOps concepts and vocabulary at Blooms Levels 1 and 2.

- Agile Coach
- Agile in Large Organizations
- Artificial Intelligence
- Bateson Stakeholder Map
- Batch Sizes
- Beyond Budgeting
- Business Case
- Business Value
- Chain of Goals
- Change Leader Development Model
- Change Management
- Chapter Lead
- Chapters
- Cognitive Bias
- Continuous Flow
- Continuous Improvement
- Continuous Integration
- Continuous Delivery
- Conversation Café
- Conway's Law
- Cumulative Flow Diagram
- Cultural Iceberg
- Current State Map
- Cycle Time
- Definition Of Done
- Deployment
- DevOps Adoption
- DevOps Coach
- DevOps Design Principles
- DevOps Kaizen
- DevOps Leaders
- DevSecOps
- Design Principles
- Flow
- Frequency
- Future State Map
- Generative AI
- Goleman's 6 Styles of Leadership
- Guilds
- Hand Offs
- High Performing IT Organization
- Karpman Drama Triangle
- Kolb's Learning Styles
- Kotter's Dual Operating System
- Laws of System Thinking
- Lead Time
- Lean Canvas
- Lean Product Development
- Little's Law
- Machine Learning
- Mental Models
- Mindset
- Minimum Viable Product
- Monitoring Tools
- Neuroscience
- Observability
- Organization Culture
- Organization Model
- Organizational Design
- Platform Engineering
- People Changes
- Process Changes
- Project Aristotle
- Psychological Safety
- Rework
- SCARF Model
- Scheduling
- Silos
- Spotify
- Squads
- StoStaKee
- Strategy Acceptance
- Target Operating Models
- Teal Organization
- Team Dynamics
- The Power of TED
- Training from the Back of the Room
- Transformational Leadership
- Tribe Lead
- Tribes
- Value Added Time
- Value-Stream Management Platform
- Value Stream Mapping
- Wait Time
- Waste
- Wicked Questions
- Wilber's Quadrants
- Work Is Performed
- World Cafe

5. Exam specification

The examination has the following structure:

Learning Outcome	Weighting %
DevOps and Transformational Leadership	15.0%
Unlearning Behaviours	12.5%
Becoming a DevOps Organization	17.5%
Measuring to Learn	5.0%
Measuring to Improve	5.0%
Target Operating Models and Organizational Designs	15.0%
Articulating and Socializing Vision	15.0%
Maintaining Energy and Momentum	15.0%
Total	100%



THE LANGUAGE OF COLLABORATION

Thank you for completing this course!

Please take a few minutes to give us your feedback on your experiences and learning from the course by completing the online course evaluation survey [here](#).



PeopleCert has been accredited by Lloyd's Register, UK (now LRQA), in accordance with ISO 14001 for Environmental Management since 2006. Recognized through numerous awards, we remain committed to ESG leadership and the preservation of our planet.